

MEN

This season, Carlos Alcaraz kept the Sincaraz streak alive and achieved a coveted goal that further cemented his place in tennis history. “You really want what you don’t have,” he confided in early January, referring to the Australian Open title, which would make him the youngest man to complete a career Grand Slam at 22. Alcaraz did just that with a four-set final victory over Novak Djokovic, the GOAT and the last active member of the Big Three. Sadly, a debilitating right-wrist injury — tenosynovitis (inflammation of the tendon sheath), to be precise — sidelined Alcaraz from early April, when he withdrew from the Barcelona Open. An update via X from Spanish tennis reporter José Morón offered some optimism that the defending champion might play the US Open: “Morning training session in Murcia with Holger Rune and Carlos Alcaraz,” wrote Morón. “Both are pushing their chances to make it to the US Open.” Days later, Alcaraz happily announced that he had entered the US Open. However, world No. 1 Jannik Sinner withdrew from the US Open because of right-knee inflammation. The ailment had kept Sinner out of competition since he won his second Wimbledon and fifth Grand Slam title with a four-set final victory over Alexander Zverev. At Roland Garros, the 29-year-old Zverev capitalised on Alcaraz’s absence and Sinner’s shocking second-round loss to No. 56 Juan Manuel Cerundolo to seize his first Major title. Let’s size up the favourites, other contenders, and the best bets to upset them. In reverse order, with an additional bonus selection, here are my picks.

FLAVIO COBOLLI

No. 10

“Sometimes I have to remind myself on the court I’m really good,” Flavio Cobolli said, following his 4-6, 7-6(3), 6-3 comeback win over torrid Rafael Jodar at the recent Cincinnati Open. If he needs a visual reminder, he can look at the Hulk tattoo inked on his right thigh in February. In his on-court interview after beating Terence Atmane at the Delray Beach Open, Cobolli explained, “In Davis Cup [last year], you remember I [ripped] my T-shirt, so now I have Hulk. It’s fresh, like two weeks old. I felt like Hulk on the court [then], so now I have to be like him!”

The charismatic Italian who saved seven match points during his heroic Davis Cup victory once again played like the superhero character at Roland Garros. Cobolli dropped only two sets — one against Felix Auger-Aliassime — en route to the final. There, he extended No. 3 Zverev to five sets.

A tremendous athlete with a huge forehand and a wicked slice serve in the deuce court and a high-kicking serve in the ad court, 24-year-old Cobolli is figuring out how to play on hard courts. At the Cincinnati Open, he took out rising stars Alexander Blockx and Jodar, plus Tommy Paul, to reach his first Masters 1000 semifinal. A secret to his success: he eats four M&M’s chocolate candies at every changeover for energy. “I love M&M’s,” he said. Is a sponsorship next?

Win or lose, the impassioned Italian is a fan favourite. “I love his aggressiveness,” said *Tennis Channel* analyst Andrea Petkovic. “You see it in his face, in his eyes.”

Prediction: Quarterfinals